slaughter, death, and deportation resulting from the war. The epigraph which records the carnage says:

> One hundred and fifty thousand in number were the men who were deported thence, one hundred thousand in number were those who were slain there, and many times as many those who died.[20]

Many who perished had fought for the Kalinga ruler; others rather more ordinary and outside the arena of war were badly affected too, innocent civilians whose lives, described as principled and virtuous, were violently interrupted by the bloodbath. The epigraph speaks of these hapless victims as well and deplores the collateral damage:

> (To) the Brahmanas or Sramanas, or other sects or householders, who are living there, (and) among whom the following are practised: obedience to those who receive high pay, obedience to mother and father, obedience to elders, proper courtesy to friends, acquaintances, companions and relatives, to slaves and servants, (and) firm devotion—to these then happen injury or slaughter or deportation of (their) beloved ones.
>
> Or, if there are then incurring misfortune the friends, acquaintances, companions and relatives of those whose affection (for the latter) is undiminished, although they are (themselves) well provided for, this (misfortune) as well becomes an injury to those (persons themselves).
>
> This is shared by all men and is considered deplorable . . .
>
> Therefore even the hundredth part or the thousandth part of all those people who were slain, who died, and who were deported at that time in Kalinga, (would) now be considered very deplorable . . .[21]

This is only part of a longer account graphically capturing the pain and repentance of Ashoka in his hour of victory, and we will return to it later. For the present, what makes the story unusual is that it is the only surviving contemporary narrative description of the catastrophe. Such narratives are scarcely known to have endured from ancient times down to ours. As we saw, the original works of those who accompanied and recorded Alexander’s campaign in India have disappeared. As against this, the narrative of the killing fields of Kalinga was composed within a few years